Writing Test, Year 9

Choose one of the writing tasks below. Write at least 150–180 words. You should use your own ideas, knowledge and experience, and support your arguments with relevant evidence.

Task 1.

Is visiting new places more enjoyable than returning to familiar ones?

Write an essay in which you:

- briefly describe a place you have visited
- explain why people enjoy discovering new places
- discuss why some people prefer returning to places they already know
- give your personal opinion, supported by reasons and examples

Task 2.

Planning a trip abroad

You are going to visit your friend's country. Write an email to your friend in which you:

- explain the reason for writing
- describe your travel plans
- ask for advice about the best time to visit, places to see and ways of travelling around
- say what you are most looking forward to seeing

Task 3.

A trip I will never forget

You are writing a post for your personal blog.

Write about a holiday or experience that did not go as planned. In your blog post:

- explain when and where the experience happened
- say who you were with
- describe what went wrong and how you felt about it
- explain how the situation ended
- say what you learnt from this experience

Speaking Test, Year 9

Directions:

In this part of the test, select three task slips from those in front of you. Next choose the one you feel most confident speaking about and put the other two face down. Then take about a minute to collect your thoughts before you start to speak on the topic. You may refer to the topic as needed. Give reasons or details to support your answer. Take a deep breath and begin.

1. Talk about the kind of photos you like taking. Include this information:
   - Did you take many photos on your last holiday?
   - What were they like?
   - What's your favourite photo from your school days?
   - Can you describe it?

2. Talk about your plans for the future. Include this information:
   - What are you going to do after classes today?
   - What are you going to do this weekend?
   - What are you going to cook this evening?
   - Are you going to go on holiday this year? Where to?
   - Are you going to buy anything this weekend? What?

3. Talk about what you like doing in your free time. Include this information:
   - What do you like doing in your free time?
   - What are your favourite leisure activities?
   - What is something you don't do now but you would like to start doing?
   - Do you play any sports or musical instruments?
   - Do you think it's important to have hobbies?

4. Talk about the food you like eating. Include this information:
   - What is your favourite food?
   - How much fresh fruit and vegetables do you eat?
   - Which food did you like when you were a child?
   - What do you like eating for breakfast/lunch/dinner?

5. Talk about your future work. Include this information:
   - What would life be like if we did not have to work?
   - Would you like to have your own business?
   - Would you like to work in another country?
   - What is the best job in your country?
   - What do you want to do for work?
   - What do your parents do for work?

6. Novelist Chuck Palahniuk said: 'The only reason why we ask other people how their weekend was is so we can tell them about our own weekend.' Do you agree?
   - What do you usually do at weekends?
   - What's the most memorable weekend you have had in the past few years?
   - What would life be like without weekends?
   - Is there anything you dislike about weekends?

7. Talk about your typical day. Include this information:
   - What time do you usually get up?
   - When do your lessons start?

- What time do you get home from school?
- What do you usually do after classes?

8. Talk about typical weather where you live. Include this information:
   - What is your favourite weather?
   - What do you think of today's weather?
   - Has the weather in your country changed over the past few decades?
   - How does the weather change your feelings?
   - When was the last time the weather destroyed one of your plans?

9. Talk about the kinds of films you like watching. Include this information:
   - How often do you go to the cinema? What have you seen recently?
   - Do you prefer going to the cinema or watching something online? Why?
   - What is your favourite kind of films?
   - Have you ever watched films in English?

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    - What is your favourite method of transport? Why?
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    - What do you find easy at school?
    - What is the most difficult subject for you?
    - Have you ever been punished at your school? What for?
    - What do you think about discipline at your school?

12. Talk about whether you like reading or not. Include this information:
    - What do you enjoy reading most?
    - Do you like reading in English?
    - Do you prefer reading books or things on the Internet?
    - Have you cried while reading a book?
    - What new books have you read recently?

13. Talk about your holidays. Include this information:
    - Where did you go last summer?
    - Who did you go with?
    - What did you do there?
    - What are you going to do this summer?
    - How do you usually travel on holiday?

14. Talk about your experiences visiting museums. Include this information:
    - What do you like most and least about museums?
    - What is the best museum you've ever been to? Talk about it.
    - Do you prefer going to museums alone or with others?
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15. Talk about a restaurant you often go to. Include this information:
    - What is your favourite restaurant and why?
    - How often do you go to restaurants?
    - What kind of restaurant would you like to open?

- Does restaurant food taste best?
- Have you ever complained about the food or service in a restaurant?

16. Talk about mobile phones. Include this information:
    - What would your life be like without a mobile telephone?
    - Can you remember your first mobile telephone?
    - Are you happy with the mobile telephone you have now? Why or why not?
    - What do you think of people who use mobile phones while driving?
    - Do young people use mobile telephones too much?

17. Talk about the kinds of sport you like doing. Include this information:
    - Do you exercise? What sort of exercise do you usually do?
    - Have you ever made friends through playing sport? How? When?
    - What kinds of activities do you enjoy most now?
    - Do you usually keep fit? Are you keeping fit now?
    - Do you prefer doing or watching sport?

18. Talk about shopping habits in your country. Include this information:
    - Do you prefer going shopping alone or with friends?
    - Which is better, shopping in shops or shopping online?
    - What is the worst shopping experience you've ever had?
    - Do you like going shopping in other countries?
    - Would you like to go on a shopping holiday?

19. Talk about London. Include this information:
    - Do you think London is the greatest city in the world?
    - What do you know about life in London?
    - What things can tourists do in London?
    - Do you think London is a cheap or expensive city?
    - Is London a dangerous place to visit?
    - Would you like to live in London?

20. Talk about your studies at school. Include this information:
    - What do you like studying?
    - Do you like studying English?
    - How has the Internet changed studying?
    - What advice would you give someone on how to study English?
    - What is the best way to study for exams?

Reading Comprehension Test, Year 9

Directions:

In this test you will read four texts. You are to do the tasks following the texts. For each task you will choose the best-suited answer (A, B, or C) or two symbols (+/- or T/F) as specified prior to each task. Mark the letter of your choice on the Answer Sheet.

TEXT 1

Mark Twain (1835-1910)

1 Mark Twain's real name was Samuel L. Clemens. He was born in Florida, Missouri, the sixth of seven children. When he was four, Sam's family moved to a small town, Hannibal, on the banks of the Mississippi River. Sam's father died when he was eleven. Soon after, Sam left school and got a job as a printer for a local newspaper.

2 Sam had several jobs in the 1850s. In 1853, he moved to New York and then to Philadelphia, where he worked for several different newspapers and began writing articles. In 1857, he returned home and worked as a riverboat pilot on the Mississippi River. But when the American Civil War started in 1861, all the traffic along the river stopped.

3 In 1861, Sam went west to Nevada with his brother, Orion, to work in the silver mines. He hoped to become rich, but he didn't find any silver. He had no money, so he got a job at a newspaper in Nevada in 1862. He started using his pen name, Mark Twain, for the first time.

4 In 1864, Sam moved to San Francisco and got a job at a newspaper there. In 1865, his big break came with the publication of his short story 'Jim Smiley and His Jumping Frog' in newspapers across the country. His writing became very popular.

5 During a trip to Europe, he met Charles Langdon. Charles showed Sam a picture of his sister, Olivia. Sam fell in love with her at first sight. They were married in 1870.

6 *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* was published in 1884. The fictional town of Saint Peters in the novel is similar to Hannibal, the town where Sam grew up. The writer Ernest Hemingway (1899-1961) later said that 'All modern American literature comes from one book by Mark Twain called *Huckleberry Finn*. There was nothing before. There has been nothing as good since.'

Now mark the sentences (T) true or (F) false.

1 Mark Twain was not a real name. ___
2 Mark Twain was an only child in the family. ___
3 Sam was eleven when his father died. ___
4 Sam worked in New York and in Philadelphia in the 1850s. ___
5 During the American Civil War, Sam worked on the Mississippi River. ___
6 Sam didn't get rich in Nevada. ___
7 His short story 'Jim Smiley and His Jumping Frog' was a success. ___
8 Charles Langdon was Olivia's father. ____
9 St Peters is a town near Hannibal in the USA. ___
10 Ernest Hemingway thought *Huckleberry Finn* was a very important novel. ___

TEXT 2

Read the text and choose the missing sentences:

A summer away from home

Many companies organise summer programmes abroad for young people aged fifteen to twenty. 11_____ Travelling without your parents is a great way to become more independent, make new friends, and see a different country. But what is it really like to go on one of these trips? We spoke to three young travellers about their experiences.

Josh Tanner went to Lagos, Nigeria

I'm really good at football, so when I heard about a football volunteer programme in Africa, I was really excited. 12_____ But after I had showed them some information on the internet, they decided that it was safe for me to go. I was feeling tired when I arrived in Lagos, and I couldn't believe how hot it was. 13_____ I stayed with the Ngembo family in an apartment in the centre of Lagos. It was very small, and I had to share a room with three boys. But everyone was really nice to me, so I soon got used to having no privacy. I worked really hard, but I enjoyed my job, too. For most of the time, I was helping a Nigerian sports coach to teach football to ten-year-old boys and girls. I had a great time there, and I really got used to living in a big, noisy African city. By the time I left, I had really started to fit in!

Rebecca Jones went to Arles, France

Last year, I spent two weeks at a summer art school for young people in Arles. Arles is a beautiful little town in Provence, in the south of France. We were staying in a campsite and sharing tents, and most of the other students were French. I was nervous at first about speaking French to them. But everyone was nice to me, and they didn't criticise my mistakes. I really gained a lot of confidence after I'd been there for a week. The course was good too. We had drawing and painting lessons every morning. Then, every afternoon, the teachers took us out into the countryside to practise our skills. The famous painter Vincent Van Gogh used to live in Arles. 14_____ It's a really beautiful place. I think I painted some good pictures while I was staying there. When Van Gogh was painting in Arles, people didn't used to like his work. Now his paintings sell for millions of pounds. Who knows? Maybe the same thing will happen to my pictures one day.

Matt Hazelwood went to Bryce Canyon, USA

Last summer, I got a job at Bryce Canyon National Park in Utah, USA. It's a beautiful place, but it was very difficult to get there! After I'd flown ten hours from London to Las Vegas, I had to get a bus to Cedar Springs, Utah. And after someone had met us there, it was another three-hour drive to the park. 15_____ Lots of young people like me were working in the park last summer. We were helping people from the US National Park Service to repair and build things like picnic tables and information signs. We also helped to repair the walking paths and make them safe. That's important because a lot of middle-aged and elderly people visit the US national parks. I had to work really hard all summer and get up very early in the morning. But I soon got used to that, and it was great to work outside in such a beautiful place. Bryce Canyon is famous for its red rocks and cliffs − and when the sun comes up in the early morning, they look amazing!

A When I'd finally arrived, I went to bed and slept for twelve hours!

B But it only took me a few days to get used to the weather.

C Many other artists used to visit the area too, and I can see why.

D There aren't any big animals in these national parks, but you can see lots of birds.

E From working with children in Africa to protecting an ancient Inca road in Peru, there are lots of different trips to choose from.

F I phoned my parents every few days, so they weren't concerned about me.

G My parents weren't so enthusiastic at first.

TEXT 3

Read the text and choose the correct answer (A, B, C, D)

A Scottish Summer Camp

Summer camps are becoming increasingly popular with young people, but what are they like? Last month, junior reporter Sally Henshaw travelled to Loch Lomond, Scotland, to find out.

'I've been travelling for ten hours,' I thought, when the minibus finally drove past a sign saying 'Welcome to Camp Lomond'. It was dark, and I just wanted to go indoors and jump into a nice, soft bed. But the camp leaders had other ideas. We all had a barbecue, then we sat around a campfire and talked (or fell asleep). Finally, one of the leaders divided us into groups of three and gave us the really bad news.

'Now it's time to put up your tents,' he said.

I don't know how three of us managed to sleep in a tent the size of a single bed, but somehow we did. When we woke up the next day, my new friend Ingrid opened the front of the tent, and we all looked out. There, shining silver between the trees, was Loch Lomond. 'Loch' means 'lake' in Scottish, and Loch Lomond is one of the

most beautiful places I've ever seen! That morning after breakfast, we went horse riding around the lake. I've never ridden in such an amazing place.

In the next few days, I went BMX biking, tried rock climbing and played volleyball every day until I couldn't stand up! It was great! The camp organises different activities every day. Most sports activities are in the afternoon, and in the morning you can choose lessons like drawing, chess, drama and cookery. I've never been very good at art or board games − and I'm not a great actor − so I went along to the cookery class. I love food, but I didn't know how to cook anything before I went to Scotland. Since I've been home, I've been baking cakes for my parents! (And they haven't been to hospital with food poisoning yet, so I must be quite good at it!)

You must work hard at a summer camp. Everybody must do chores, and you do activities all day, too − you can't just sit around and hang out. But I really had a great time. The best thing about the camp was making new friends. Since I came home, Ingrid and I have been texting every day. The activities are great, but the people are even better.

Have you ever wondered what it's like to go on a summer camp? I'll tell you the answer in two words: exhausting and fun!

16 How did Sally feel when she first arrived?
- A She was hungry and cold.
- B She missed her family.
- C She was angry with the camp leaders.
- D She wanted the evening to end early.

17 The next morning, Sally
- A put up a tent.
- B saw something amazing.
- C rode a horse for the first time.
- D cooked breakfast on a campfire.

18 What types of activities did Sally do at the camp?
- A Sports and cooking.
- B Drama and art.
- C Art and sports.
- D Drama and cooking.

19 What happened after she came home from the camp?
- A Ingrid visited her.
- B Her parents went to hospital.
- C She made something for her parents.
- D She emailed Ingrid photos of the camp.

20 Overall, how does Sally feel about Camp Lomond?
- A It was too tiring.
- B It was a very good experience.
- C She didn't like sleeping in a tent.
- D It helped her to become a friendlier person.

TEXT 4

Read the text and choose the correct answer (A, B, C, D)

Falling for TV

Apparently, historians are still arguing about the complex reasons for the fall of ancient Roman civilisation. By contrast, could it be that the fall of modern western civilisation has a simple explanation? Neil Postman, who has taught media studies at New York University, thinks that it does. He claims that the root of the problem can be summed up with only two letters: TV.

Postman highlights the sharp contrast between our culture, with the TV at its centre, and an older typographic culture that had the printed book at its centre. In that older culture, if people wanted to find out about their world they would have to read, and reading is often considered an activity that naturally encourages people to think more about the world they live in. Although, of course, some of the writing was humorous, the culture based on the printed word was generally thoughtful, serious, and rational. It was also a culture that gave status and fame to highly intelligent people who had read widely and could express themselves well in writing.

That all changed when TV moved to the centre of culture. To see the effect of TV consider, for instance, the news, which is supposed to be the serious side of the medium. For a start, there is the music and the impressive graphics, telling the viewers that the news is actually another show. Viewers are then given a selection of facts, usually only those accompanied by images because, according to Postman, TV gives more emphasis to images than words. The show skips quickly from one item to the next, with little time to dwell upon each story. As a result, the viewer is encouraged to think less and just let the mind go where the sequence of images takes it.
Actually, Postman is not entirely against TV. He says TV is full of junk, but he also says that 'The best things on TV are its junk.' What he disagrees with is the way TV helps to create a public life in which the activity of thinking carefully about and discussing the serious issues that society faces looks more and more like an old-fashioned hobby. Surely Postman is right when he says that if we stop thinking seriously about the ideas and principles that our society is based on then we really will have fallen a long way.

21. What do we learn about Neil Postman from the article?
    A. He teaches history.
    B. He was born in New York.
    C. He dislikes all TV programmes.
    D. He is critical of Western culture.

22. The author mentions the news on TV because …
    A. it is supposed to be serious.
    B. it is the most popular programme.
    C. it doesn't emphasise images.
    D. it tells the truth about reality.

23. What is not said about the news on TV in this article?
    A. It moves quickly from one topic to another.
    B. Only some events get into the news.
    C. It sometimes includes music.
    D. It is a very popular type of programme.

24. According to the article, in western TV culture …
    A. no one reads books any longer.
    B. people are not encouraged to think much.
    C. everyone watches too much television.
    D. people are encouraged to buy more than they need.

25. What opinion does the author of the article have about Neil Postman's ideas?
    A. He disagrees entirely with Postman.
    B. He agrees with at least one main idea.
    C. He thinks Postman's ideas about TV are wrong.
    D. He is not sure that Postman is right.

Grade 9 keys

Listening

1. T
2. T
3. T
4. F
5. F
6. C
7. C
8. B
9. B
10. A
11. C
12. C
13. A
14. A
15. C

READING

1. T
2. F
3. T
4. T
5. F
6. T
7. T
8. F
9. F
10. T
11. E
12. G
13. B
14. C
15. A
16. D
17. B
18. A
19. C
20. B
21. D
22. A
23. D
24. B
25. B

Writing Test, Year 9

Choose one of the writing tasks below. Write at least 150–180 words. You should use your own ideas, knowledge and experience, and support your arguments with relevant evidence.

Task 1.

Is visiting new places more enjoyable than returning to familiar ones?

Write an essay in which you:

- briefly describe a place you have visited
- explain why people enjoy discovering new places
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Task 3.

A trip I will never forget

You are writing a post for your personal blog.

Write about a holiday or experience that did not go as planned. In your blog post:

- explain when and where the experience happened
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- describe what went wrong and how you felt about it
- explain how the situation ended
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Speaking Test, Year 9

Directions:

In this part of the test, select three task slips from those in front of you. Next choose the one you feel most confident speaking about and put the other two face down. Then take about a minute to collect your thoughts before you start to speak on the topic. You may refer to the topic as needed. Give reasons or details to support your answer. Take a deep breath and begin.

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6. Novelist Chuck Palahniuk said: 'The only reason why we ask other people how their weekend was is so we can tell them about our own weekend.' Do you agree?
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TEXT 1

Mark Twain (1835-1910)

1 Mark Twain's real name was Samuel L. Clemens. He was born in Florida, Missouri, the sixth of seven children. When he was four, Sam's family moved to a small town, Hannibal, on the banks of the Mississippi River. Sam's father died when he was eleven. Soon after, Sam left school and got a job as a printer for a local newspaper.

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5 During a trip to Europe, he met Charles Langdon. Charles showed Sam a picture of his sister, Olivia. Sam fell in love with her at first sight. They were married in 1870.

6 *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* was published in 1884. The fictional town of Saint Peters in the novel is similar to Hannibal, the town where Sam grew up. The writer Ernest Hemingway (1899-1961) later said that 'All modern American literature comes from one book by Mark Twain called *Huckleberry Finn*. There was nothing before. There has been nothing as good since.'

Now mark the sentences (T) true or (F) false.

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8 Charles Langdon was Olivia's father. ____
9 St Peters is a town near Hannibal in the USA. ___
10 Ernest Hemingway thought *Huckleberry Finn* was a very important novel. ___

TEXT 2

Read the text and choose the missing sentences:

A summer away from home

Many companies organise summer programmes abroad for young people aged fifteen to twenty. 11_____ Travelling without your parents is a great way to become more independent, make new friends, and see a different country. But what is it really like to go on one of these trips? We spoke to three young travellers about their experiences.

Josh Tanner went to Lagos, Nigeria

I'm really good at football, so when I heard about a football volunteer programme in Africa, I was really excited. 12_____ But after I had showed them some information on the internet, they decided that it was safe for me to go. I was feeling tired when I arrived in Lagos, and I couldn't believe how hot it was. 13_____ I stayed with the Ngembo family in an apartment in the centre of Lagos. It was very small, and I had to share a room with three boys. But everyone was really nice to me, so I soon got used to having no privacy. I worked really hard, but I enjoyed my job, too. For most of the time, I was helping a Nigerian sports coach to teach football to ten-year-old boys and girls. I had a great time there, and I really got used to living in a big, noisy African city. By the time I left, I had really started to fit in!

Rebecca Jones went to Arles, France

Last year, I spent two weeks at a summer art school for young people in Arles. Arles is a beautiful little town in Provence, in the south of France. We were staying in a campsite and sharing tents, and most of the other students were French. I was nervous at first about speaking French to them. But everyone was nice to me, and they didn't criticise my mistakes. I really gained a lot of confidence after I'd been there for a week. The course was good too. We had drawing and painting lessons every morning. Then, every afternoon, the teachers took us out into the countryside to practise our skills. The famous painter Vincent Van Gogh used to live in Arles. 14_____ It's a really beautiful place. I think I painted some good pictures while I was staying there. When Van Gogh was painting in Arles, people didn't used to like his work. Now his paintings sell for millions of pounds. Who knows? Maybe the same thing will happen to my pictures one day.

Matt Hazelwood went to Bryce Canyon, USA

Last summer, I got a job at Bryce Canyon National Park in Utah, USA. It's a beautiful place, but it was very difficult to get there! After I'd flown ten hours from London to Las Vegas, I had to get a bus to Cedar Springs, Utah. And after someone had met us there, it was another three-hour drive to the park. 15_____ Lots of young people like me were working in the park last summer. We were helping people from the US National Park Service to repair and build things like picnic tables and information signs. We also helped to repair the walking paths and make them safe. That's important because a lot of middle-aged and elderly people visit the US national parks. I had to work really hard all summer and get up very early in the morning. But I soon got used to that, and it was great to work outside in such a beautiful place. Bryce Canyon is famous for its red rocks and cliffs − and when the sun comes up in the early morning, they look amazing!

A When I'd finally arrived, I went to bed and slept for twelve hours!

B But it only took me a few days to get used to the weather.

C Many other artists used to visit the area too, and I can see why.

D There aren't any big animals in these national parks, but you can see lots of birds.

E From working with children in Africa to protecting an ancient Inca road in Peru, there are lots of different trips to choose from.

F I phoned my parents every few days, so they weren't concerned about me.

G My parents weren't so enthusiastic at first.

TEXT 3

Read the text and choose the correct answer (A, B, C, D)

A Scottish Summer Camp

Summer camps are becoming increasingly popular with young people, but what are they like? Last month, junior reporter Sally Henshaw travelled to Loch Lomond, Scotland, to find out.

'I've been travelling for ten hours,' I thought, when the minibus finally drove past a sign saying 'Welcome to Camp Lomond'. It was dark, and I just wanted to go indoors and jump into a nice, soft bed. But the camp leaders had other ideas. We all had a barbecue, then we sat around a campfire and talked (or fell asleep). Finally, one of the leaders divided us into groups of three and gave us the really bad news.

'Now it's time to put up your tents,' he said.

I don't know how three of us managed to sleep in a tent the size of a single bed, but somehow we did. When we woke up the next day, my new friend Ingrid opened the front of the tent, and we all looked out. There, shining silver between the trees, was Loch Lomond. 'Loch' means 'lake' in Scottish, and Loch Lomond is one of the

most beautiful places I've ever seen! That morning after breakfast, we went horse riding around the lake. I've never ridden in such an amazing place.

In the next few days, I went BMX biking, tried rock climbing and played volleyball every day until I couldn't stand up! It was great! The camp organises different activities every day. Most sports activities are in the afternoon, and in the morning you can choose lessons like drawing, chess, drama and cookery. I've never been very good at art or board games − and I'm not a great actor − so I went along to the cookery class. I love food, but I didn't know how to cook anything before I went to Scotland. Since I've been home, I've been baking cakes for my parents! (And they haven't been to hospital with food poisoning yet, so I must be quite good at it!)

You must work hard at a summer camp. Everybody must do chores, and you do activities all day, too − you can't just sit around and hang out. But I really had a great time. The best thing about the camp was making new friends. Since I came home, Ingrid and I have been texting every day. The activities are great, but the people are even better.

Have you ever wondered what it's like to go on a summer camp? I'll tell you the answer in two words: exhausting and fun!

16 How did Sally feel when she first arrived?
- A She was hungry and cold.
- B She missed her family.
- C She was angry with the camp leaders.
- D She wanted the evening to end early.

17 The next morning, Sally
- A put up a tent.
- B saw something amazing.
- C rode a horse for the first time.
- D cooked breakfast on a campfire.

18 What types of activities did Sally do at the camp?
- A Sports and cooking.
- B Drama and art.
- C Art and sports.
- D Drama and cooking.

19 What happened after she came home from the camp?
- A Ingrid visited her.
- B Her parents went to hospital.
- C She made something for her parents.
- D She emailed Ingrid photos of the camp.

20 Overall, how does Sally feel about Camp Lomond?
- A It was too tiring.
- B It was a very good experience.
- C She didn't like sleeping in a tent.
- D It helped her to become a friendlier person.

TEXT 4

Read the text and choose the correct answer (A, B, C, D)

Falling for TV

Apparently, historians are still arguing about the complex reasons for the fall of ancient Roman civilisation. By contrast, could it be that the fall of modern western civilisation has a simple explanation? Neil Postman, who has taught media studies at New York University, thinks that it does. He claims that the root of the problem can be summed up with only two letters: TV.

Postman highlights the sharp contrast between our culture, with the TV at its centre, and an older typographic culture that had the printed book at its centre. In that older culture, if people wanted to find out about their world they would have to read, and reading is often considered an activity that naturally encourages people to think more about the world they live in. Although, of course, some of the writing was humorous, the culture based on the printed word was generally thoughtful, serious, and rational. It was also a culture that gave status and fame to highly intelligent people who had read widely and could express themselves well in writing.

That all changed when TV moved to the centre of culture. To see the effect of TV consider, for instance, the news, which is supposed to be the serious side of the medium. For a start, there is the music and the impressive graphics, telling the viewers that the news is actually another show. Viewers are then given a selection of facts, usually only those accompanied by images because, according to Postman, TV gives more emphasis to images than words. The show skips quickly from one item to the next, with little time to dwell upon each story. As a result, the viewer is encouraged to think less and just let the mind go where the sequence of images takes it.
Actually, Postman is not entirely against TV. He says TV is full of junk, but he also says that 'The best things on TV are its junk.' What he disagrees with is the way TV helps to create a public life in which the activity of thinking carefully about and discussing the serious issues that society faces looks more and more like an old-fashioned hobby. Surely Postman is right when he says that if we stop thinking seriously about the ideas and principles that our society is based on then we really will have fallen a long way.

21. What do we learn about Neil Postman from the article?
    A. He teaches history.
    B. He was born in New York.
    C. He dislikes all TV programmes.
    D. He is critical of Western culture.

22. The author mentions the news on TV because …
    A. it is supposed to be serious.
    B. it is the most popular programme.
    C. it doesn't emphasise images.
    D. it tells the truth about reality.

23. What is not said about the news on TV in this article?
    A. It moves quickly from one topic to another.
    B. Only some events get into the news.
    C. It sometimes includes music.
    D. It is a very popular type of programme.

24. According to the article, in western TV culture …
    A. no one reads books any longer.
    B. people are not encouraged to think much.
    C. everyone watches too much television.
    D. people are encouraged to buy more than they need.

25. What opinion does the author of the article have about Neil Postman's ideas?
    A. He disagrees entirely with Postman.
    B. He agrees with at least one main idea.
    C. He thinks Postman's ideas about TV are wrong.
    D. He is not sure that Postman is right.

Grade 9 keys

Listening

1. T
2. T
3. T
4. F
5. F
6. C
7. C
8. B
9. B
10. A
11. C
12. C
13. A
14. A
15. C

READING

1. T
2. F
3. T
4. T
5. F
6. T
7. T
8. F
9. F
10. T
11. E
12. G
13. B
14. C
15. A
16. D
17. B
18. A
19. C
20. B
21. D
22. A
23. D
24. B
25. B

ІІ етап Всеукраїнської учнівської олімпіади з англійської мови
Writing Test, Year 11

Choose one of the writing tasks below. Write 200 –250 words. Use your own ideas, knowledge and experience. Support your arguments with relevant examples. Use an appropriate style and structure.

Task 1.
The happiest day of my life

A magazine is running a writing competition.
Write an article in which you:
• describe what happened on the happiest day of your life
• explain why this day was especially important to you
• reflect on how this experience influenced you or your outlook on life

Task 2.
Young people should live with their parents for as long as they want.

Write an opinion essay in which you:
• clearly state your opinion on the statement
• give at least two reasons to support your point of view
• explain why some people may disagree with you
• restate your opinion in the conclusion

Task 3.
Does modern technology make young people more independent?

Write a for-and-against essay in which you:
• discuss arguments in favour of the idea that modern technology helps young people become more independent
• discuss arguments against this idea
• give your own opinion, supported by reasons and examples

Speaking Comprehension Test, Year 11

Directions: Select three task slips from those below. After selecting three, choose one you on which you can expand most and return the other two to the table face down. Then take about a minute to collect your thoughts before you begin to speak on the topic. You may refer to the topic as needed. Take a deep breath and begin.

In this test you will be asked to discuss a topic. Do you agree or disagree with the sentence? Give reasons or details to support your answer. Talk for at least three minutes.

1. Violent computer games should be banned.
2. The sale of cigarettes should be made illegal.
3. Homework should be limited to just two nights a week.
4. Should school students be required to wear school uniform?
5. What is the best way to become the most popular teen in school?
6. Dogs should be banned from cities.
7. The internet is the best way to do the shopping.
8. Young people under 15 shouldn't use mobile phones.
9. All young people should stay at school until they are 18.
10. There shouldn't be any advertising on TV during children's programmes.
11. Famous celebrities shouldn't complain if paparazzi take photos of them every day.
12. It is the children's responsibility to look after their parents when they get old.
13. Tell me about a holiday you've had.
14. Tell me about a difficult journey you've had.
15. Tell me about a perfect day you've had.
16. Tell me about a special event in your life.
17. Tell me about a birthday you remember.
18. Tell me about a time when you lost something important.
19. Tell me about a time when you gave someone a surprise.
20. What are the advantages and disadvantages of shopping for bargains?

ІІ етап Всеукраїнської учнівської олімпіади з англійської мови
Reading Comprehension Test, Year 11

Directions: In this test you will read FOUR texts. You should do the tasks following a text based on what is stated or implied in that text. For each task you will choose the best possible answer from four possible answers (A, B, C, D) or tick one option from three, as specified prior to each task. Mark the letter of your choice on the Answer Sheet.

Text 1

Read the article. For questions 1-5, choose the correct answer (A, B, C, or D).

Beach Heroes

There is no more welcome sight on beaches all over the world than a lifeguard.

You can spot the lifeguards a mile off – which is, of course, half the point. Not only do they wear highly conspicuous red-and-yellow uniforms, but somehow, they manage to look better than the rest of us too.

'Last year, we only had to make five rescues,' says head lifeguard Rod Terry, 22. 'Another year, we helped 29 people in the space of three hours. You never know what you're going to be called upon to do, which is why you need lifeguards who can cope with any situation.' You'd think, of course, they'd all be keen to perform some public heroics, but Rod is quick to rebuff any such suggestions.

'As far as we're concerned, we'd far rather stop someone getting into trouble than have to get them out of it.' One of the lifeguards in Rod's team is 24-year-old Rebecca Surridge. She says, 'One minute you can find yourself dealing with minor cuts and grazes, and the next with a situation where one group of people on the beach is annoying another group. You have to be ready for anything. You also have to handle things sensitively.' Even if they do talk tough, the lifeguards have no legal authority with which to back up their words. 'We can only advise,' adds Rod. 'If someone wants to ignore a red flag, they're free to do so. 'A red flag is what the lifeguards put out when the sea's too rough for swimming. Exactly when that moment is reached it is something that Rod alone decides. A lifeguard from the age of 14, first as a volunteer, he's now a paid member of the town council's leisure services department. 'You take into account a variety of things: you listen to the weather reports and forecasts, and you assess the strength of the wind.' Other factors to be considered, depending on location, of course, are the dangers that may be lurking in the water.

The vast majority of swimmers take notice of a red flag, but there are always those who don't, and long before they start really getting into trouble, lifeguards will be on their way out to them, dragging with them a 'torpedo' buoy, which is a long sausage-shaped inflatable on the end of a rope. This can help them bring in swimmers suffering from cramps, brought on by swimming too soon after a meal, or fatigue caused by swimming out too far. 'Then you get the silly ones who jump off the harbour wall,' sighs Rod. 'Mostly, though, swimmers stick within our exclusion zone. This is a 100 m x 100 m patch of sea. The prime rule of the exclusion zone is that boats are forbidden to enter it – and humans are forbidden to leave it. Within the exclusion zone, even a rubber ring found floating out at sea is pursued and retrieved, it could set off a coastal-wide emergency search.

At any one time, there are eight lifeguards on duty, either scanning the waves or patrolling the beach (lifebelts need checking, telephones need to be kept working in case of emergency calls). The team works five days a week and constantly has to rotate tasks as this assures that lifeguards' will work with premium attentiveness to their responsibilities. The other thing that keeps the lifeguards alert is the fact that they all get on well together. 'It's not as if we're all sitting there in silence,' says Lisa. 'We're always talking to each other, either in person or by two-way radio.'

In fact, each summer season is something of an old friend's reunion; this is the seventh year Pete has worked here, while it's the fifth for Rebecca. Come wintertime, they go off round the world – Pete's been surfing in Mexico and Rebecca's just back from Bali, Hawaii and New Zealand. It's a case of not yet wanting to give up their seasonal, sunlit round of beaches. 'There's plenty of time for a proper job later,' says Rebecca.

1. According to Rod Terry, lifeguards need to be ...
A athletic.
B flexible.
C attentive.
D hardworking.

2. Rebecca Surridge says that lifeguards ...
A operate in limited areas.
B have limited powers over people.
C are trained to deal with limited injuries.
D watch over a limited number of people.

3. According to the text, which factor does NOT affect a lifeguard's decision to put up a red flag?
A the presence of something dangerous in the sea
B the quality of the water in the sea
C the environmental conditions
D the number of swimmers

4. In order to maintain their concentration levels, lifeguards ...
A sometimes ask their colleagues for feedback.
B regularly change the duties they perform.
C usually take several days off each week.
D often take long breaks during the day.

5. It's common for a group of lifeguards ...
A to have another job at the same time.
B to meet up when they're not working.
C to work together in the same location.
D to go travelling together when the summer is over.

Text 2
Read the article. For questions 6-10, choose the correct answer (A, B, C, or D).

A Step in The Right Direction

It was once famously said that some things in life – like paying taxes and death – are inevitable. Trying to find employment after leaving education is another thing that young people everywhere have to face. But despite the large amount of research that has been undertaken on young people in the job market, relatively little is known about what happens once young people start their first job. A team of researchers from Leeds Metropolitan University investigated this question. A survey focused on 39 employers and addressed a range of issues in relation to recruitment, to employment, and particularly to young people's experiences in the workplace.

It is clear from the interviews with young people that, for the vast majority, the idea of a 'job for life' no longer exists. While some had clear career ambitions, the majority appeared to be unclear on

what they wanted to do. One consequence of this is that many young people saw their early work experiences as temporary – a 'stop gap' until their ideas on what they wanted to do had developed, or simply a way of earning money to pursue other ambitions such as travel.

This tendency has also been noted by many employers and is particularly disappointing to smaller businesses looking for long-term loyalty in their staff. However, some employers, for example, in areas such as financial services and call centres – have adjusted to the new situation, and appear to have accepted that they cannot expect young people to see a long-term future with one employer.

Like a number of other studies, the findings confirm that employers tend to focus on 'softer' skills and behavioural qualities in the recruitment process, with a less prominent role played by formal qualifications. The opinions of this sample of young people were remarkably consistent with those of the employers. Most of the young people seemed to have understood the message that formal qualifications are often a necessary but not sufficient condition for obtaining the types of jobs which they hope to do in the future. They recognised that skills like communication, working in a team, organisation, and customer service are all important. There was evidence that many young people had clearly worked on developing such skills.

Where there does appear to be a significant difference of opinion between the views of young people and employers related to the extent to which young people possess the necessary 'employability' skills. By and large, the young people interviewed were confident in their ability to demonstrate these skills and qualities. Employers, on the whole, were much less positive about this, often feeling that educational institutions were focusing too strongly on academic skills and qualifications, at the expense of employability.

Another area where employers' and young peoples' views differed is in relation to Information Technology (IT) skills. When asked about the things they value most about young recruits, many employers mentioned their ability to use computers. On the other hand, few young people mentioned this explicitly. The probable explanation is that young people simply take their IT skills for granted, often not realising how valuable they might be to some employers. Encouraging young people to be more positive about this aspect might help some to improve the way they are viewed by potential employers.

In terms of the induction process provided for their young recruits, the results of this study confirmed both expectations and the findings of earlier research – that employers vary widely in the nature of the training they provide. Differences included the length of time the orientations ran, how formal the training was, what topics were covered, and how often training occurred. The reaction of most young people to the induction they had experienced was positive, or at least neutral. There is clearly a tension between the need for new recruits to become good at their jobs, and their understandable desire to get to work as quickly as possible.

From the point of view of the employer, much depended upon the nature of the job, the type of employer (particularly size and sector), and the frequency with which they recruit young people. In general, the more regularly young people were recruited and the larger the employer, the more formal the induction process.

In uncertain economic times, it seems that young people, now more than ever, are having to do all they can to find employment.

6. The survey revealed that, in general, young people ...

A do not value the early work experience they gain in any way.
B are unconvinced they will do the same job until they retire.
C would prefer to have a gap year before starting higher education.
D are unsure about which jobs they want to do when they leave school.

7. What do employers think about formal qualifications?

A They are less important than behavioural qualities.

B They are more important than behavioural qualities.
C They are equally as important as behavioural qualities.
D They are more important than behavioural qualities for certain jobs only.

8. What can we learn from the survey about young people and IT skills?
A Employers do not assume that all young employees have good IT skills.
B Young people need to perfect their IT skills before starting work for an employer.
C Young people should promote their IT skills to employers more than they do currently.
D Employers do not enjoy feeling inadequate as young people's IT skills are often superior to theirs.

9. The survey suggests that young people themselves value skills such as being able to...
A get the job done faster than others.
B get new business for the company.
C get better results than colleagues.
D get on with other people in the workplace.

10. Induction processes vary in terms of ...
A where they are carried out.
B who they are reviewed by.
C when they take place.
D what they focus on.

Text 3

Read the text. Match sentences A–F with gaps 11–15. There is one extra sentence.

Identical twins

Identical twins are born when an egg divides into two, resulting in the birth of two children with identical genes. 11___ Some believe, however, that there is also a close connection between twins in the way they think, not just in the way they look. Twins finish each other's sentences and share the same tastes in clothes or music. Some have argued that identical twins have mysterious, even psychic, powers.

Although many identical twins claim to know what the other is thinking, there is no evidence to suggest that this is because of special powers. 12___. Most of us have met up with a brother or sister, or close friend, and immediately asked, 'What's wrong?' because we have unconsciously recognised, in their facial expression, that they are upset in some way. Signs we would miss in a stranger's behaviour are instantly obvious in the way those close to us act.

It is hardly surprising that twins notice the way their brother or sister's facial expressions or body language gives away how they feel. Indeed, the closeness of their bond is likely to improve this ability over the years.

The media is full of stories in which a twin senses her brother or sister to be in trouble. 13___ Damien Croft developed a bad headache one evening and, concerned, felt the need to phone his brother to check if everything was OK. When there was no reply, he drove to his brother's home, only to find him unconscious, having had an epileptic fit and fallen from a ladder while decorating. On the face of it, his sixth sense had saved the day. 14___ Damien knew his brother was decorating and knew that he was prone to epileptic fits. Subconsciously concerned, he had just imagined the worst-case scenario. 15 ___

A In a recent, widely-reported case, for example, a young man survived a horrific fall thanks to a feeling his twin is supposed to have had.

B We all know such twins are often very similar in appearance.

C The fact that something awful had happened was only a coincidence.

D In contrast, there are many other stories which can be more easily explained.

E In truth, of course, the events might also be explained in more ordinary terms.

F A more believable explanation is that, like any pair of people who have grown up together, they are just good at understanding the thought processes behind what their twin does.

Text 4

Use of English

Read the text below. For questions (16-25) choose the correct answer (A, B, C or D). Write your answers on the separate answer sheet.

Many people claim to be able to know when someone is lying. According (16)_____ . popular belief, all you have to do is look at a person's body language; when a person is lying he becomes nervous and fidgety, touches his nose, and bites his nails. However, a researcher at Portsmouth University, England, has arrived at an entirely (17)_____ conclusion. Dr Samantha Mann carried (18)_____ research on the behaviour of suspects who had given (19)_____ statements in police interviews. Mann discovered that liars actually stay quite (20)_____ . This is because they are aware that people are looking for body language that could suggest they are lying. Therefore, liars actually touch their noses 20% less than people who tell the truth. The same (21) _____ for eye contact. While it is generally thought that liars (22)_____ eye contact and blink rapidly, in reality, people who are lying (23)_____ sure to maintain eye contact and control their blinking. With the findings of her research in mind, Mann claims that the best way to (24) _____ a liar is to look for people who are trying too hard to (25)_____ truthful.

16	A from	B by	C to	D with
17	A another	B different	C other	D the other
18	A up	B down	C in	D out
19	A closing	B false	C mistaken	D open
20	A stationary	B at rest	C still	D slow
21	A goes	B comes	C stays	D moves
22	A avoid	B run	C prevent	D escape
23	A keep	B make	C take	D do
24	A exhibit	B develop	C emerge	D spot
25	A view	B display	C show	D appear

GRADE 11 KEYS

LISTENING

1. F
2. T
3. F
4. F
5. F
6. F
7. T
8. B
9. D
10. A
11. B
12. C
13. C
14. D
15. A

READING

1. B
2. B
3. C
4. B
5. C
6. B
7. A
8. C
9. D
10. D
11. B
12. F
13. A
14. E
15. C
16. C
17. B
18. D
19. B
20. C
21. A
22. A
23. B
24. D
25. D